

GRIM TALES

TERROR STRIKES ACROSS THE COUNTRY LEAVING A TRAIL OF SHATTERED HOMES, BROKEN SPIRITS AND VICTIMS FLOATING IN A FORGOTTEN LIMBO. THEY ARE LEFT TO PICK UP THE PIECES, LONG AFTER THE SPOTLIGHTS HAVE DIMMED AND THE VIP VISITORS MOVED ON.

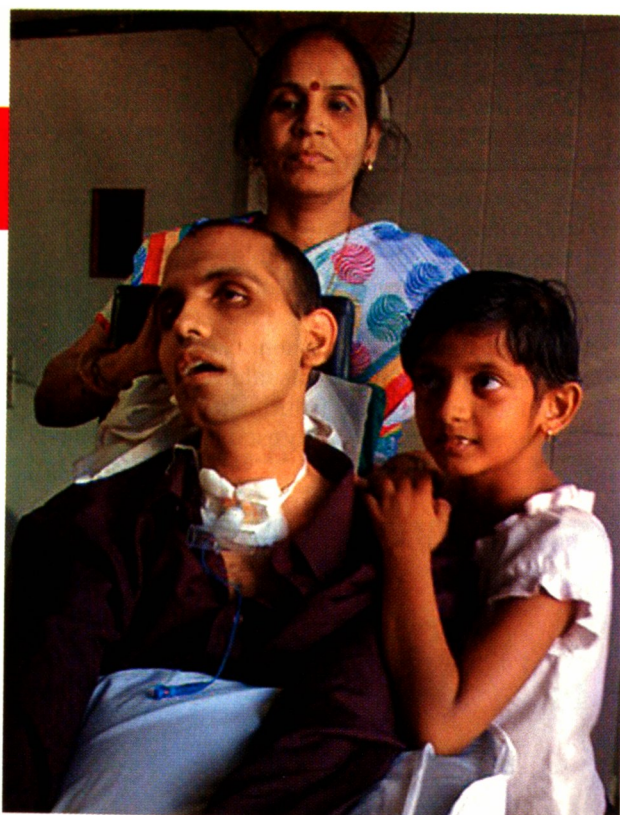
AMIT SINGH, 22, Student

Mumbai train blasts, July 11, 2006

WHAT HAPPENED

SEVERE BRAIN INJURY AND HAS BEEN LYING IN A VEGETATED STATE SINCE

He was returning home to Virar after collecting admission forms for an MCA course when a bomb ripped through his train compartment. Two years later, the commerce graduate lies strapped to his bed in the high-dependency unit at Jaslok Hospital. "He can feel our touch and hear us speak, but he cannot react," says his mother Meena. The doctors have warned that Amit might not be able to move around on his own, ever. But the parents, reeling under a severe financial crunch, are still hopeful. Amit's hospital bills are taken care of by the government, but the family has already spent a huge amount on travelling to be with their son. "We have exhausted our savings and desperately need financial help," says Meena. Despite newspaper features on every anniversary of the blasts and visits by top politicians, the Singh family is yet to see any light at the end of this dark journey.



SANGITA PATNI, 26 Housewife

Ahmedabad serial blasts, July 26, 2008

WHAT HAPPENED

LOST HER HUSBAND IN THE AHMEDABAD BLASTS

It is now 50 days since Vijay Patni, 27, fell victim to the bomb blasts while working as temporary ward boy in Ahmedabad Civil Hospital, leaving behind a young wife, three small children and parents. The

joint family lived on Vijay's monthly pay of Rs 2,500 besides the earnings of his parents, both of whom are small vegetable vendors. Sangita has already received Rs 5 lakh as compensation from the Gujarat Government. She is expecting another Rs 3 lakh from the Union Government. But the family asks, "Can money erase the scars left behind by such a cruel death and that too engineered by fellow human beings?"

A deadly mix of anger and depression can clearly be seen on the

faces of his wife and parents. Says father Sonjibhai Patni, 59, who belongs to the brave Dataniya Vaghri community, "If the Government can't hang these beasts in minimum possible time, then they should be handed over to us. We Vaghris know how to deal with such monsters."

But on the face of Sangita, who lives with her in-laws in a two-room chawl, depression is unmistakable. Says Sangita, whose three children are aged between five and one year, "With these children, how will I sustain for the rest of my life?"